Racial Barriers

Alive and Well in Davidson

I. History of communication and cooperation between the college and community.

II. Formation and Goals of Griffith Street Properties, Incorporated.

III. Community concerns on the issue.

IV. Suggestions for the future.

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Peridiocally,during the past fifty years, members of the college have played a significant role in the development of the Davidson community. Indeed, many of the improvements in the standard of housing in the Black community can be attributed to the work of members of the college faculty. Recently, however, the work of Griffith Street Properties seeking to beautify the entrance to the college has become a heated issue in the community. In addressing this present concern, I will trace the history of communication and cooperation between the college and community, discuss the formation and goals of Griffith Street Properties, Incorporated, present some of the community's concerns and look to the future for suggestions as to how, in the 1980's, can we continue to address the ongoing dilemma of segration within our own community.

Beginning in the 1950's, the college YMCA, with the support of Reverend Carl Prittchet, the minister of Davidson College Presbyterian Church, addressed the issue of sub-standard housing in Davidson. By co-signing bank loans with the college YMCA, a number of members of the Black community were able to invest in home improvements.[1]

In the late sixties, the Community Development Committee, under the leadership of Dr. Daniel Rhodes, led a campaign to build low-cost housing. The community, working through the Farmers Home Administration, secured no-interest loans for the building of Lakeside Park subdivision. Moderate income Black citizens were able to obtain mortgages when they otherwise would not have been able to secure a bank loan. H. B. Naramore, a local industrialist and member of the Town Council, supported the project by providing a large donation to pay for the land.[2] "Davidson College financed street, water and sewer construction by selling fourteen lots for $42,000."[3] The sixty-five units of housing established by this project provided the first nice homes for many of the residents of the Black community. Most importantly, the work done by the Community Development Committee provided a model for the Farmers Home Administration's work with low-interest bank loans which later became national policy.[4]

In the late 1970's, the same committee, under the direction of Dr. Charles Ratliff, worked to provide improvements for existing housing in the Black community and to finance new Section 8 apartments. Through a half million dollar grant from the Housing and Urban Development Agency, members of the community updated their homes with storm windows and doors, insulation and general home improvements. Furthermore, with the help of government funding, Lakeside Apartments were built and provided additional low-cost housing for the community.[5]

During the early seventies, an outside study was done to evaluate the growing development of the county towards Davidson. Both the construction of Lake Norman in the early sixties and plans for the extension of Interstate 77, alerted town planners to consider long term goals and objectives for the community. The study recommended five needs which include the following:

1. The revitalization of downtown Main Street by developing the local businesses.
2. The improvement of the residential situation by elimination of substandard housing.
3. The construction of a motel.
4. The development of a retirement community.
5. The updating of the zoning ordinance.[6]

In response to these needs, the college agreed to the following:

1. To move an auxiliary enterprise downtown. (Plans for moving the bookstore to Main Street are still being considered.)
2. To acquire property for the site of the new post office.
3. To assist in the development of Lakeside Apartments.
4. To purchase five acres of land at the intersection of Griffith Street and Interstate 77, for the site of a motel.[7]

Furthermore, plans are currently being made for the new retirement community.

The most recent attempt to address Davidson's housing issue has been led by Howard Covington. Although Mr. Covington said the, "effort had its inspiration years ago related to a concern for people living in a substandard housing primarily," his main concern is with beautifying the entrance to the College:[8]

> I just kept seeing these houses painted all kinds of wild colors and junk cars in the front...and I didn't think this was a good entryway to a beautiful college campus.[9]

Covington, along with John A. Tate (former president of Piedmont Bank), Lawrence Kimbrough (former lawyer for Piedmont Bank), and Bob Currie (Davidson College business manager), incorporated Griffith Street Properties in 1981. The stated goal of the corporation is to, "preserve, restore, renovate, upgrade, develop, and take all action necessary to improve and promote the revitalization of the Griffith Street area."[10]

Although the college technically is not involved with the corporation financially, it is difficult to define those boundaries. Covington, a college trustee, "has invested around $75,000 of his own money in the project."[11] Furthermore, the

corporation is funded in part, by ~~the~~ alumni donations to the college, earmarked for that specific project. "So far, a half dozen individuals and three or four corporations have made donations for Griffith Street Properties."[12] Finally, "the articles (of the corporation), say that any assests of the corporation will become property of the college after the group dissolves."[13] Among the possible uses for the acquired land are residential homes, a park, or simply, re-landscaping the area.

Understandably, members of the community are suspicious of the corporation and assume it is primarily a college project.

> Mr. Covington said the corporation is willing to trade property with home owners along the street, to buy property outright, or to pay to have homes moved. 'We would go several ways,' he said.[14]

However, one suggestion that has not been considered, is to help Griffith Street residents improve their homes where they stand. Home improvement loans, or even construction of new homes on the same lots could serve to improve the asthetic appearance of Griffith Street. These approaches are not what Mr. Covington has in mind. In an interview with the Davidsonian last spring, he rejected such a suggestion:

> You can take a hound dog and cut his tail off and cut his ears off and tie a ribbon around his neck and he is still a hound dog.[15]

He continued:

> There is a total lack of desire or unwillingness on the part of some of the Black families to improve their living standard.[16]

Nevertheless, in the same interview he remarked:

> It's a long, slow process and some people are still entrenched there, and some are still suspicious. We are not out to displace anybody.[17]

On the whole, community response to Griffith Street Properties, Inc. has been negative, but several residents have already sold their homes to the corporation. Mrs. Rosie Patterson was the first homeowner to agree to swap houses with the corporation. Her old house was appraised at $20,000 while the new house is worth $40,000. "Mrs. Patterson, who now lives at 187 Park Drive [said],

I think I got a good deal."[18] However, other residents have been insulted by the offer and are suspicious of the corporation's intentions:

> 'It doesn't make much sense,' [said Margaret Latter, 70, who lives at 348 Griffith Street.] 'This is home,' [she said.] 'I've had a lot of work done here. I'm not going to be shifted off anywhere.'[19]

William Torrence, although not a resident of Griffith Street, has been greatly offended by what the corporation proposes. He feels that the Black community is being, "pushed back as far as it possibly can and at any cost."[20] He further remarked that the corporation has made, "an unfair gesture with no consideration for the people who have saved and scraped pennies for their homes."[21] Whether or not Griffith Street Properties is totally fair in their dealings with the community, is not the only issue to be considered.

While rumors and talk of, "the college buying-up Griffith Street" have circulated since 1981, the community did not confront the issue until late spring 1984. In response to the resident's concerns about Griffith Street, the Community Relations Board invited the corporation's members to an open meeting, in June 1984. Mr. Currie and Mr. Kimbrough represented the corporation. Reports of the meeting were negative, and apparently tempers got out of hand. Gerald Carr, a football coach for Davidson and former resident of Griffith Street, acted as a spokesman for the community. He remarked that the one question that was never answered was why the corporation could not invest their money in improving the homes where they are presently. Mr. Covington refused to attend the meeting and subsequent offers for future dates. On the whole, the confrontation did little to improve communication or understanding on either side.

Although frustrated, the community has continued to seek answers. The September Community Relations meeting focused on land ownership rights and how to determine a fair price for property. Garfield Carr, president of the Community Relations Board, feels that at this point there is little else that the board can do for the people of Griffith Street. "Now they know their rights and the decision is up to them."[22] He feels many will sell if they get the right price. The Community Relations Board, revitalized by the issue, is now looking to the larger concerns of the community. At the October meeting, plans were discussed to invite Mayor Russell Knox to address the group. The group also expressed a desire to have more students and members of the college participate in meetings.

The Griffith Street issue may be quiet for now, but the causes of the problem still exist and continue to effect Davidson's Black community in many ways. There is a general

feeling among Black residents that the college runs the town and they have little or no say in what happens. Mrs. Irvin McClain remarked that while she served on the Community Betterment Association, she had some input. At that point there were two blacks and three or four whites on the committee. Since her resignation of her seat, however, she feels that the majority of the community boards have regressed to tokenism. Furthermore, she said the committees have a "bad habit of having the meetings in the morning which is bad for working people."[23] Also, when serving on a committee she often felt that decisions were made without the Black members present.[24] This same concern was echoed by Pat Johnson, director of the Davidson Community Center and former reporter for the North Mecklenburg Gazette. As a reporter covering the Town Council meetings for the past five years, she found herself confused on several issues because private discussions occurred outside of the open meetings. When this happened it was difficult to determine how decisions were made on certain issues. In general, a spectator had little hopes of following issues at Town Council meetings.[25] Pat also remarked that the Gazette hesitated to ruffle the college and generally stayed away from controversial issues such as Griffith Street.

Racial barriers are alive and well in Davidson. The desegregation that occurred successfully in the elementary school has not extended into the larger community. The white children participate in the YMCA while the Black children frequent the Community Center. Kenneth Norton, the barber, remains as the only Black merchant on Main Street. For the most part, Blacks continue to work in the same custodial positions that their parents and relatives have worked in for generations. However, the greatest tragedy, is that Davidson College, as an institution, has not taken strides to improve race relations within the community, and has instead, permitted members of its Board of Trustees and administration to be involved with a project that has probably set back effective communications at least twenty years.

There comes a point when we must decide how far-reaching Davidson's value system extends. I believe that if our Statement of Purpose is really as noble as we all hope, that it can at least cross the railroad tracks that divide our town physically, racially, and economically. The College has a responsibility to our community and particularly to the people who have served it for years. I do recognize that Davidson College has responded to many of the community's needs. However, the doubts and fears that have been expressed by the people who have been asked to move from Griffith Street can no longer be ignored. If the alumni group is really seeking to improve the community, these fears need not exist. Considering the resources, concern, and motivations of Griffith Street Properties, Inc., there must be constructive alternatives to relocating a neighborhood. After all, these are not merely "eyesores"; these are

families and homes, and needs that must be met--that can be met if better cooperation between both sides is achieved. The cooperative effort, however, must now come from the College.[27]

There are many positive steps that the college can take to improve the relationship with the Black community. Some are costly, but others just require commitment:

1. Have a representative of the college administration attend each Community Relation Board meeting.
2. Evaluate salary and benefits for hourly wage employees.
3. Provide skill training, workshops, and/or adult education for all college employees.
4. Encourage Black businesses to develop by providing low-interest loans and financial advice.
5. College administrators on the Town Council should continue to actively seek to involve Blacks on town planning boards.

My personal feeling concerning the Griffith Street issue is one of frustration. The issue is not just Griffith Street; it involves the entire attitude, motivations and goals of the College community. Concerning the issue, Willie Torrence remarked that it is all a matter of, "understanding where people are coming from, and willingness for people to get together and discuss their frustrations."[28] The history of Davidson's community development has reflected both periods of cooperation and conflict. The future of the community-college relationship demands both commitment and effort on the part of the Davidson College faculty, staff, administration and students.

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Endnotes

[1]Telephone interview with Dr. Charles Ratliff, 6 November, 1984.

[2]Telephone interview with Dr. Daniel Rhodes, 6 November, 1984.

[3]Ted Mellnik, "Davidson's Urban Renewal a Private Affair," The Charlotte News, evening ed., 26 March, 1984, Sec. A, p. 10, col. 5.

[4]Rhodes, Nov. 1984.

[5]Ratliff, Nov. 1984.

[6]Personal interview with Bob Currie, 26 October, 1984.

[7]Currie, Nov., 1984.

[8]Ross Holt, "Alumni Group Seeks to Buy Griffith Street Land," The Davidsonian, 3 February, 1984, p. 1.

[9]Mellnik, p. 1A, col. 1.

[10]Holt, p. 4.

[11]Holt, p. 4.

[12]Mellnick, p. 10A, col. 5.

[13]Holt, p. 4.

[14]Mellnick, p. 10A, col. 5.

[15]Personal interview with Ross Holt, (quoting his interview with Howard Covington of Feb. 1, 1984.) 5 November, 1984.

[16]Holt, (Covington), Nov., 1984.

[17]Holt, p. 4.

[18]Mellnik, 1A, col. 1.

[19]Mellnik, 10A, col. 5.

[20]Telephone interview with William Torrence, 6 November, 1984.

[21]Torrence, Nov. 1984.

[22]Personal interview with Garfield Carr, 23 Oct. 1984.

[23]Telephone interview with Mrs. Irvin McClain, 6 November, 1984.

[24]McClain, Nov. 1984.

[25]Personal interview with Pat Johnson, 31 October, 1984.

[26]Johnson, Oct. 1984.

[27]Beth Maczka, "Recognize the Community's Needs," The Davidsonian, 10 February, 1984, p. 13.

[28]Torrence, Nov. 1984.